HONG KONG–SHENZHEN / AN EXPLORATORY STUDY

WHEN LIVES SPAN A BORDER

What do everyday experiences reveal about opportunities and adjustments?

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At JB Sentral

Research and presentation: Jamie Ko / Visual support: Bob / Field photographs supplied by Bob and Jamie

A Hong Kong-centred inquiry, returning to Singapore–Johor with questions. Pictured people are not identified as participants.

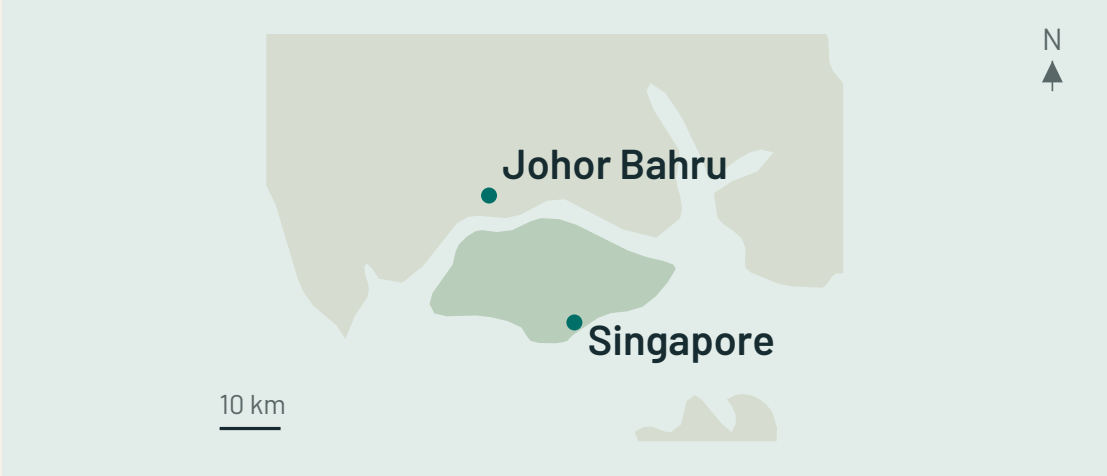
THE REGIONAL CONTEXT

A FAMILIAR QUESTION. DIFFERENT ARRANGEMENTS.



Hong Kong–Shenzhen

One country; different systems



Singapore–Johor

JS-SEZ in Johor / RTS is a separate rail link

MTI / EDB, JS-SEZ factsheet (2025) [1]; LTA / Malaysia MOT (2026) [2]; Natural Earth locator geometry

Selected places only; no zone or route boundaries shown. RTS target: February 2027, subject to approvals.

WHAT EXISTING RESEARCH TELLS US

THREE VIEWS OF CROSS-BORDER LIFE

Systems

Economic, institutional and social processes

2014

Shen / historical analysis

Purchases

Different mixes of spending across places

2025

Gao, Han & Song / mainly data to 2024

Activities

Home, work and other activities can be closer or further apart

2026

Xiao, Cai & Zhang / 2023 data

Shen (2014) [3]; Gao, Han & Song (2025) [4]; Xiao, Cai & Zhang (2026) [5]

Different geographies, periods and methods; these studies do not form a single before-and-after series.

HOW THE INQUIRY WAS BUILT

TWELVE SETS OF NOTES. TWO EXPERT DISCUSSIONS.

12

Informal conversations and visits

Including one Sheung Shui visit with three brief chats

2

Separate expert discussions

Read alongside studies, official statistics and programme documents

Illustrative experiences, not a representative interview sample

Research method and current source notes [7–8]

Twelve mixed records, not twelve interviewees. The three Sheung Shui chats belong to one visit record.

AN ADAPTED WAY TO READ THE MATERIAL

THREE LENSES

A **Livelihoods and choices**
Household choices and local business conditions

B **Everyday services and navigation**
Practical information and services people encounter

C **Relationships and support**
Ties that continue and connections that develop

Institutions run across all three.

Selected themes adapted from Arup / Resilient Cities Network, City Resilience Framework (2024) [6]
These are study lenses, not official framework dimensions or a measured resilience score.

FOUR OVERLAPPING ARRANGEMENTS / 1–2

DIFFERENT WAYS TO CROSS

01 CROSS-BORDER USER



Repair customer

Parts & expertise



Dining visitors

Choice, space & price

02 NORTHBOUND MOVER



Guide who moved north

A home and a preferred occupation

Illustrative accounts [7] / conceptual avatars are role illustrations, not participant portraits

Arrangements describe behaviour and can overlap. All individual accounts are paraphrased.

FOUR OVERLAPPING ARRANGEMENTS / 3–4

WORK, HOME AND TIES NEED NOT SHARE A CITY

03 CROSS-BORDER WORKER / STUDENT



Schooling illustration

16,139

daily cross-boundary pupils

2024/25 · official evidence

04 HONG KONG BASE / MAINLAND TIES



Professional with Shenzhen ties

Works & rents in HK

Property, family & friends in Shenzhen

Participant account [7]; Education Bureau, 2026/27 Estimates, annex table 1 [9]

The student is a research illustration, not an interviewee. Mainland homes are not necessarily Shenzhen. Avatars are conceptual.

PEOPLE WHO REMAIN LOCALLY BASED / SHEUNG SHUI

THE LOCAL ACCOUNTS MATTER TOO



Sheung Shui store manager

Fanling home
Sheung Shui work



Sheung Shui resident

Local routines
Infrequent crossings



Sheung Shui shop employee

An estate shop
Nearby customers

Three brief Sheung Shui chats and walking observations, 31 October 2026 [8]

Three distinct accounts, not a local population sample. Conceptual avatars are not portraits of the people interviewed.

LENS A / HOUSEHOLD CHOICES

DIFFERENT REASONS TO CROSS

CROSS-BORDER USER



Repair customer

Parts

Expertise

Older equipment · a specialist capability

CROSS-BORDER USER



Dining visitors

Choice · space · price

Online alternatives

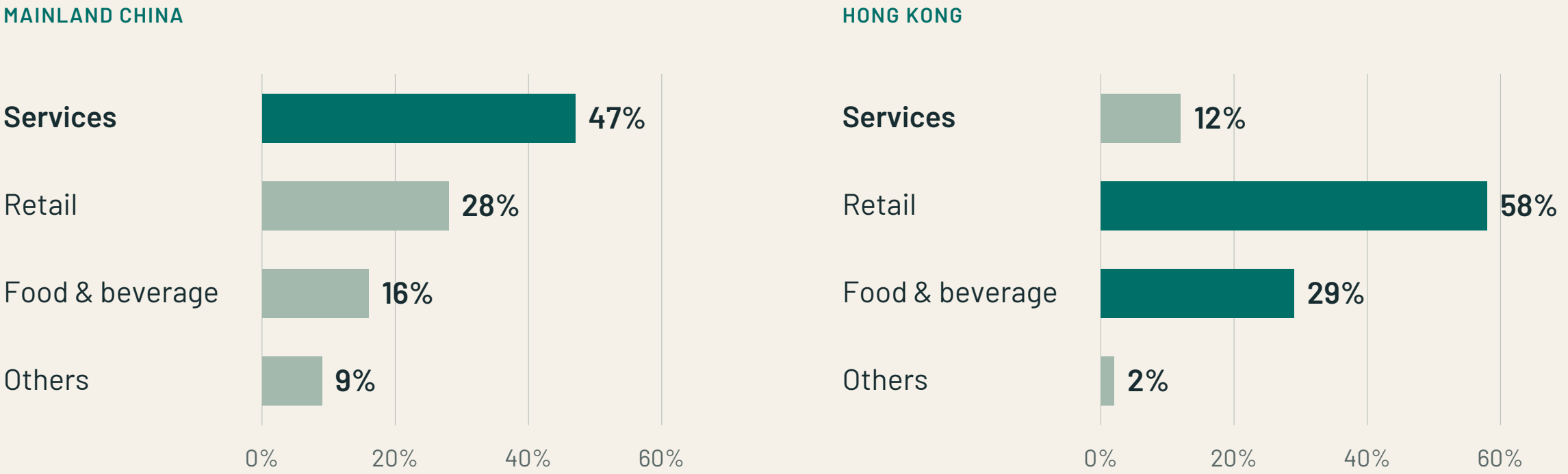
Dining visitors · more ways to access a purchase

Repair customer and dining visitors: reported experiences and observation [7]

Paraphrases, not quotations. A visit and an online purchase are different ways of accessing alternatives. Avatars are conceptual.

LENS A / PUBLISHED CONSUMPTION EVIDENCE

DIFFERENT PLACES. DIFFERENT BASKETS.



Share of recorded spending within each location · seasoned AlipayHK users

CUHK research release, Figure 3 · 19 June 2025 [4]

Shares of expenditure; labels rounded (HK totals 101%). Mainland is broader than Shenzhen. Not a measure of displaced spending.

LENS A / SELECTING PARTICULAR ACTIVITIES

SOME ROUTINES CROSS. OTHERS STAY.



Sheung Shui store manager

Visits about monthly

Mainly for meals · most shopping in Hong Kong



Sheung Shui resident

Infrequent crossings

Crowding is a reason

Sheung Shui store manager and resident: separate accounts [8]

Reported routines, not measured behaviour or a representative sample. Conceptual role illustrations.

LENS A / AN EXPERT'S PERSONAL EXAMPLE

A VISIT ALSO NEEDS TIME

WEEKENDS IN HONG KONG

Child's activities

Little time for Shenzhen



IF THE ARRANGEMENTS FIT

Childcare arranged

Half a day available

Price and travel time are only part of the choice.

Expert discussion: one personal example [7]

A conditional example, not a measured threshold or a general claim about parents' choices.

LENS A / A LARGER HOUSEHOLD CHANGE

A PREFERRED OCCUPATION. A WORKABLE BALANCE.



NORTHBOUND MOVER

Guide who moved north

Tour guiding

Lower earnings

Lower living costs

Prepared financially before moving

Guide who moved north: reported aspirations and trade-offs [7]

No verified saving percentage or general claim that movers benefit. The conceptual avatar is not a participant portrait.

LENS A / LOCAL BUSINESS CONDITIONS

WHICH MEALS CAN MOVE?



Guide who moved north

THE GUIDE'S COMPARISON

Lunch near work

Daily location · available time

Planned leisure meal

More scope to choose where to go

Guide who moved north: a participant's interpretation [7]

A comparison of routines, not measured restaurant impacts or a claim that all everyday meal providers are protected.

LENS A / LOCAL BUSINESS CONDITIONS

ONE TOWN. DIFFERENT CUSTOMERS.

ESTATE SHOP



Sheung Shui shop employee

Mainly nearby residents

Few tourists described

LANDMARK NORTH



Sheung Shui store manager

Locals + Mainland visitors

Busier Monday–Thursday

Sheung Shui shop employee and store manager: distinct staff accounts [8]

Reported customer mixes and routines, not measured market shares or a causal business-impact estimate.

LENS A / OBSERVATIONS THAT NEED FOLLOW-UP

WHAT CHANGES OVER TIME?

LOCAL CROWDS



Fewer crowds, in two accounts

Comparable footfall data needed

CHAINS AND INDEPENDENTS

Does scale help operators adapt?

Familiar chains observed; an expert suggested scale may help.

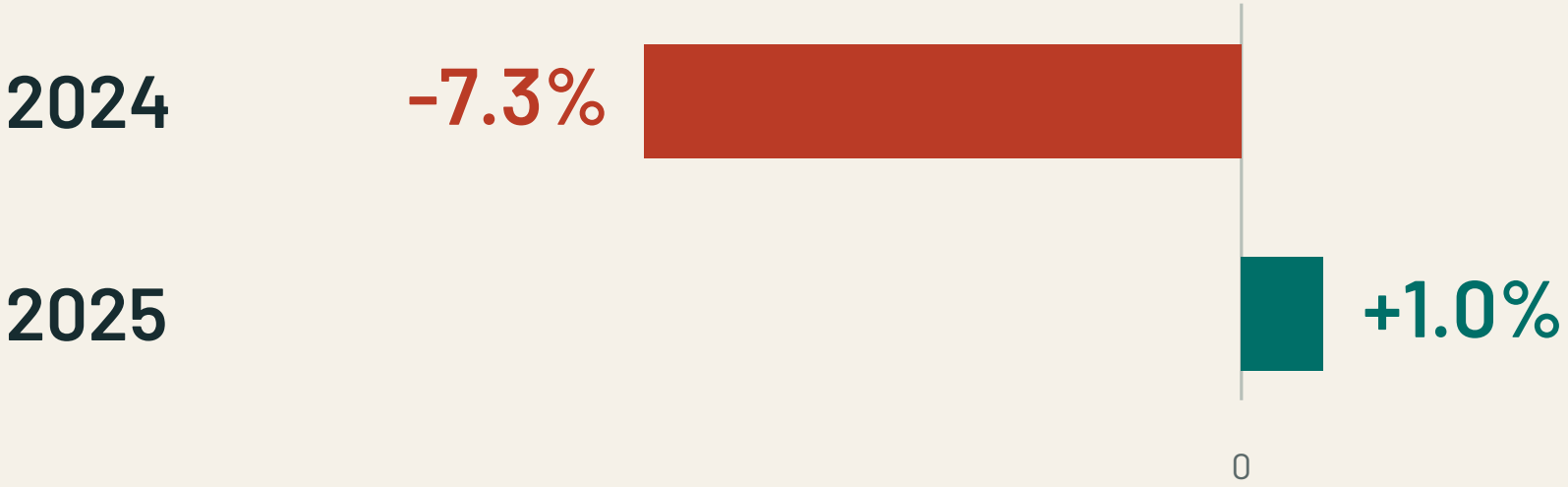
Sheung Shui accounts and walking observation [8]; expert discussion [7]

Neither changing footfall nor relative business survival is established by these observations.

LENS A / CITYWIDE CONTEXT

RETAIL CHANGED ACROSS YEARS

ANNUAL CHANGE IN HONG KONG RETAIL-SALES VALUE



Local reports of fewer crowds need comparable footfall data.

Census and Statistics Department, retail-sales value [10]; Sheung Shui accounts and observation [8]

Value, not volume. These citywide changes do not isolate the effect of Shenzhen or establish a local footfall trend.

LENS A / TAKEAWAY

SELECTIVE CHOICES. DIFFERENT PRESSURES.

WHAT IS BOUGHT

Price, specialist services and experiences

WHO IS SERVED

Different purchases and customer groups

WHEN IT FITS

Time, convenience and crowding

The accounts point to variation within "cross-border demand".

Synthesis of selected accounts, published consumption research and retail context [4, 7–8, 10]

An exploratory finding; no estimate of net welfare, representative household gains or causal business losses.

LENS B / FUTIAN ARRIVAL AND GUIDANCE

TWO DIFFERENT FORMS OF HELP

ARRIVAL PROCESS

Immigration staff → Arrival-form kiosk

NEAR THE EXIT / STAFFED HELP POINTS

Practical information for everyday life

Living · career · services · study · business



Guides at the help centre

Futian visit and dated field-note addendum [7]; photograph supplied by Bob and Jamie

Immigration assistance and staffed information are separate. Photograph shows help-centre guides; completed referrals were not tested.

LENS B / COMMERCIAL SERVICES IN VIEW

EVERYDAY SERVICES AROUND THE CROSSING



VISIBLE STOREFRONTS

Dental care

Delivery services

Phones and SIM cards

PROPERTY AGENT'S ACCOUNT

Restaurants catering to Hong Kong tastes; tuition for Hong Kong-curriculum students

Futian field observation, property-agent account [7]; original photograph supplied by Bob and Jamie

Visible provision and reported offerings are distinct. No claim about users' identities, service quality or outcomes.

LENS B / SHEUNG SHUI FIELD OBSERVATION

SERVICES FOR CROSS-BORDER NEEDS

DRIVING-LICENCE CONVERSION

Hong Kong ⇄ Mainland

Assistance advertised by a local driving school



Sheung Shui observation [8]; Jamie's photograph of Lee Kin Driving School

The signs advertise driving-licence conversion, not vehicle registration-plate conversion. Provision is observed; uptake is not measured.

LENS B / A PUBLISHED HEALTHCARE ARRANGEMENT

FOLLOW-UP CARE ACROSS THE BORDER

HKU-SHENZHEN HOSPITAL / FOLLOW-UP CONSULTATION PILOT

>5,900

Eligible Hospital Authority patients

Joined by January 2026

SEPARATE ARRANGEMENTS

Medical records

Return referrals

HKSAR Government replies, 25 February and 17 June 2026 [12]

Defined eligibility. The enrolment figure describes programme use, not clinical outcomes or universal coverage.

LENS B / TAKEAWAY

GUIDANCE AND SERVICES

Aimed at cross-border needs

FINDING A STARTING POINT

Practical information for unfamiliar arrangements

MAINTAINING EVERYDAY ROUTINES

Services relevant to people moving between the two places

Futian and Sheung Shui observations and accounts [7–8]; published care arrangements [12]

Observed and reported provision; effectiveness, service quality and completed referrals were not assessed here.

LENS C / CONTINUING CONNECTIONS

LIVES CAN STAY CONNECTED

HONG KONG

SHENZHEN

Work & rented home



Property, family & friends

Professional with Shenzhen ties

Family visits



Home & community life

Guide who moved north

Professional with Shenzhen ties and guide who moved north: accounts [7]

Connections, not regular commutes. Property is one participant's explanation of home. Conceptual avatars are not portraits.

LENS C / HELP THROUGH CONNECTIONS

A LEAD. HER ACTION. LATER HELP.



Guide who moved north

01 → **02** → **03** → **04**

Friends

An opportunity to qualify

Her action

Pursued it; said she passed

Reluctance

Age-related, in her account

Intervention

Someone helped her obtain work

Guide who moved north: reported sequence [7]

One account, not a general age rule or verified licensing requirement. The avatar is a conceptual role illustration.

LENS C / JOINING NEW CIRCLES

WHERE NEW CIRCLES BEGIN

SHENZHEN



Guide who moved north

Guiding friendships

Sports & interests

Food-related activities

HONG KONG



Dining visitors

Sports & coaching

Volunteering

Animal activities · beach cleaning

She considered Mandarin useful for joining in.

Guide and dining visitors: reported examples [7]

The dining visitors discussed Hong Kong activities during the Shenzhen outing. Examples do not establish programme effects.

LENS C / TAKEAWAY

TIES CONTINUE. CONNECTIONS FORM.

CONTINUING TIES

Family and relationships across cities



Professional



Guide

NEW CONNECTIONS

Entry points through work and shared interests



Guide



Dining visitors

Synthesis of the professional, guide and dining visitors' accounts [7]

Specific accounts of connection and help, not a population measure of belonging. Illustrations identify roles, not likenesses.

QUESTIONS WORTH EXPLORING / 1 OF 3

HOW DO BUSINESSES EVOLVE? WHAT HAPPENS TO WORKERS?





FOLLOW THE CHANGES

Products · customers · business models

Workers' next jobs and earnings

A household can gain as a customer while facing pressure at work.

Further inquiry arising from the exploratory accounts

Research questions, not assessed impacts. Detailed measurement proposals remain in the research appendix.

QUESTIONS WORTH EXPLORING / 2 OF 3

WHEN DOES A SERVICE BECOME USEFUL?



FROM PROVISION TO USE

Which needs do providers identify?

Do users get the help they seek?

Whom does existing help miss?

Further inquiry prompted by observed help points and commercial services

Provision does not establish effectiveness. The photograph records information on display, not a completed service outcome.

QUESTIONS WORTH EXPLORING / 3 OF 3

HOW DO MOVERS KEEP TIES AND BUILD NEW ONES?



Guide who moved north

ENTRY POINTS INTO LOCAL LIFE

Work · interests · friends

Who lacks support?

What helps people connect and contribute?

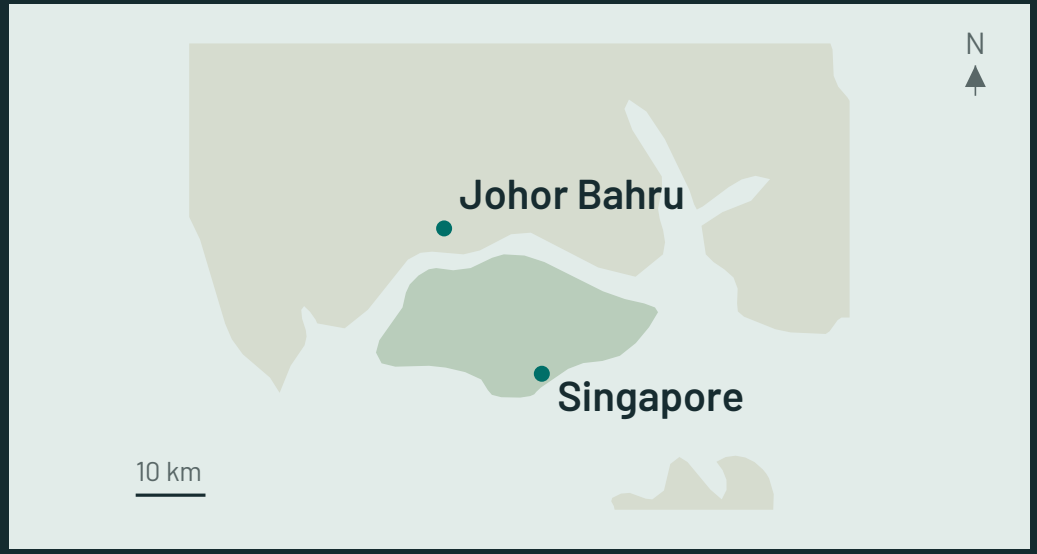
Further inquiry arising from the professional's and guide's accounts

Questions for community organisations and researchers; no population measure of support, attachment or contribution.

RETURNING TO SINGAPORE–JOHOR

CARRY THE QUESTIONS.

Find the answers locally.



Different work, residence and service arrangements

SPENDING

Which purchases, customers and locations change?

LIVES

What becomes feasible, and what stays connected?

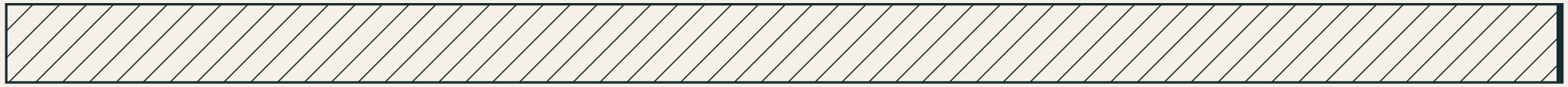
Singapore–Johor questions / JS-SEZ factsheet [1]; RTS timing [2]; Natural Earth locator geometry

Singapore and Malaysia are separate countries. Similar journeys do not imply the same rights or outcomes.

SINGAPORE–JOHOR / RTS SPENDING FORECAST

SPENDING IN BOTH DIRECTIONS

Singapore consumers to Johor Bahru



S$1.05bn

Johor Bahru consumers to Singapore



S$756m

About S$290m net incremental outflow

Additional annual consumer spending / S$ million / hatch = forecast

SBF / RAS / SRA commissioned RTS study, 16 July 2026 [13]

Forecasts, not realised spending, GDP or JS-SEZ effects. Rounded gross inputs imply S$294m; source reports about S$290m.

SINGAPORE–JOHOR / A PRACTICAL PROPOSAL

LEARN FROM OPERATORS IN HONG KONG AND SHENZHEN

ASSOCIATION-LED LEARNING VISIT

Singapore retailers and service businesses

→

Customer patterns & offerings

What operators have tried

What fits local circumstances

Include difficult and unsuccessful adaptations, too.

SINGAPORE–JOHOR / CONDITIONAL INTEREST

IF TRAVEL BECAME EASIER...

Around 1 in 3

Singapore respondents could envisage buying a JB home and retiring there.

Conditional interest / Blackbox, 2024

HOUSEHOLD QUESTIONS TO EXPLORE

Information and services?

Ties in Singapore?

Connections in Johor?

Whom does support miss?

Blackbox Research, SensingSG, February 2024 [14]

Conditional stated interest, not observed migration or one-third of all Singaporeans. Household requirements are questions to explore.

SINGAPORE–JOHOR / WHO IS ALREADY THERE?

KEEP JOHOR RESIDENTS IN VIEW

OPPORTUNITIES

What changes for local businesses and workers?

PEOPLE ALREADY LIVING IN

JOHOR

Questions, not assessed effects

ACCESS

What happens to housing and everyday services?

Singapore–Johor questions / exploratory comparison

This project has not assessed these effects. Johor is more than a lower-cost option for incoming households.

WHAT THIS EXPLORATORY STUDY CONTRIBUTES

EVERYDAY EXPERIENCES MAKE INTEGRATION CONCRETE

A Choices and competitive pressures differ across purchases, customer groups, convenience and time.

B People encounter guidance and everyday services aimed at cross-border needs.

C Relationships can continue across cities while new connections form through work and shared interests.

WHAT THIS EXPLORATORY STUDY CONTRIBUTES

OPPORTUNITIES. ADJUSTMENTS. EVERYDAY LIVES.

Follow businesses, workers, service users and movers over time.

Questions for Singapore–Johor to explore locally.

Explore the research

Research and presentation: Jamie Ko / Visual support: Bob

Exploratory experiences and questions. Full sources, field photographs and interactive research accompany this presentation.